prejudices of the colonizers. But its importance and symbolic value is not for the city inhabitants alone. The Taj symbolizes the nation in many ways. As T.M. Mbeki, President of South Africa, wrote to Ratan in the aftermath of the 26/11 attacks, ‘I have thought that it [Taj] is an inalienable part of that intangible presence, the soul and identity of the Indian people.’

On 26 November 2008, a Wednesday evening, the Taj became a target for four heavily armed terrorists belonging to the Lashkar-e-Taiba. They had vowed to destroy the Indian spirit; but the virtually unarmed hotel staff were equally determined not to capitulate. The assault was sudden and ferocious. But it failed in its objective because ‘the very next day [the day after the operations concluded], Mumbaikars came back to work. Hotel staff reported for their shifts,’ as Obama said while honouring the victims of the attack.

For Ratan, the day of the attack was about to end like any other normal working day. He had reached home after work. Around 9.35 p.m. his phone rang. It was the septuagenarian Noshir Soonawala; he usually never called so late. Soonawala asked him, ‘Do you know what is going on at Taj? There seems to be some kind of firing happening there.’ Soonawala had been alerted by his friend whose son was at the Taj when the terrorist attack had begun. The friend had called him to find out if he could talk to the security to spirit his son to safety.

Ratan was in disbelief. He immediately called the Taj to check what was going on. When the operators who manned the exchange 24x7 failed to respond, it was an ominous sign.

Around the same time, R.K. Krishna Kumar had reached home and was retiring for the night when he heard of the attack from Raymond Bickson, MD of Indian Hotels, who was at the Taj having dinner with his wife and a banker friend. Kumar decided to drive straight to the hotel. Ratna, his wife, accompanied him as she was not willing to let him go alone.

Krishna Kumar reached the hotel and attempted to enter the lobby. A temporary hotel driver, Kamlesh Mandal, who was present when the attack had begun, realized the danger and prevented him from going inside, as the lobby had already become a killing ground. Krishna Kumar nearly lost his temper and shouted at him, Mandal remembers; but the driver stood his ground. At one point a shrapnel from a grenade hit Krishna Kumar and he started bleeding from the wound. Realizing that it would be unsafe to remain where they were, Mandal led him away to safety.